



HERE'S TO THE MAN WHO KILLED MY SISTER

FESTEN / 1998

IN CONTEXT

GENRE

Family drama

DIRECTOR

Thomas Vinterberg

WRITERS

**Thomas Vinterberg,
Mogens Rukov**

STARS

**Ulrich Thomsen,
Henning Moritzen,
Thomas Bo Larsen**

BEFORE

1960 Jean-Luc Godard brought a new and radical filmmaking style to *À bout de souffle*.

AFTER

1998 The second Dogme movie is Lars von Trier's *The Idiots*, about a group of friends who pretend to be disabled for their own amusement.

1999 US director Harmony Korine makes the first non-European Dogme movie, *Julien Donkey-Boy*.

On March 13, 1995, a group of Danish filmmakers came together to create an artistic manifesto. There were many rules in this document, but the core idea behind the Dogme 95 movement was the removal of artifice from cinema. Knocking away creative crutches and devices, from music to superficial dramatic tropes such as murder, the goal was to purify movies, to tell stories that are focused entirely on the characters and the moment they are in.

The first Dogme movie, *Festen* (*The Celebration*), was Thomas Vinterberg's contribution to the

movement. Following Dogme rules, the movie takes place in one setting, a family-run hotel hosting a patriarch's 60th birthday dinner. His three estranged children return for the occasion and dark secrets are exposed. The claustrophobia and intense realism of the filming style add to the pressure-cooker atmosphere gradually built up by the proceedings.

The speech

Festen subverts social conventions, perhaps most tellingly in its use of a formal speech to expose the truths under the veneer of familial



Thomas Vinterberg Director

Thomas Vinterberg was born in Copenhagen, Denmark,

in 1969. After graduating from the national film school of Denmark in 1993, he made his feature debut with *The Biggest Heroes*, a road movie that was met with acclaim in his native Denmark. He later formed the Dogme 95 movement with fellow directors Lars Von Trier,

Kristian Levring, and Søren Kragh-Jacobsen. His movie *Festen* was the first, and most successful, of the movement, and was met with international acclaim, including winning the jury prize at Cannes.

Key movies

1996 *The Biggest Heroes*
1998 *Festen*
2003 *It's All About Love*
2012 *The Hunt*